AJP 2026 policy platform, summary

Animals can't vote, but their lives are shaped by decisions made in parliament every day. That's why we exist: to bring animals into the conversation, and to show that what's good for animals is usually good for people and the planet too. This is a plain-language summary of what we're campaigning for. It's more detail than our election manifesto, and much shorter than our full policy platform, which sets out the evidence, legislation and reasoning behind every commitment.

We know change takes time, and that farmers, workers and communities need real support to get there. Nothing here is about punishing anyone. It's about building something better, together.

Ending the cruellest farming and fishing practices

New Zealand's animal welfare rules are meant to protect animals, but in practice they're often inadequate, poorly enforced, or simply ignored. We want to ban the most intensive and harmful practices first: intensive winter grazing, breeding fast-growing chickens, live exports, mutilations, and bottom trawling. Longer term, we support a full transition away from animal farming, done fairly and with proper support for the people who currently depend on it.

We'll push for:

- An urgent ban on the cruellest, most intensive farming and fishing methods
- A funded transition scheme so farmers can move to plant-based or other work on their own terms
- Tighter standards and stronger enforcement of the Animal Welfare Act

Recognising animals as sentient, not property

Animals in New Zealand are currently classed as property under the law, with no enforceable right to a decent life. We want animal sentience properly written into legislation, not just mentioned in passing, and the outdated property classification abolished.

We'll push for:

- Legal recognition of animals as sentient beings, with real protections attached
- An end to codes of practice that let industries sidestep the Animal Welfare Act
- A future legal framework that treats animals as individuals, not commodities

Making healthy, plant-based food the easy choice

Right now, animal-based foods dominate menus in schools, hospitals and other public places, even where health alone should point the other way. We want plant-based meals to be the default option everywhere they're served publicly, clearer labelling so people know what's really in their food, and GST removed from fruit, vegetables, legumes and nuts.

We'll push for:

- Plant-based defaults in public institutions, with other options still available
- Fair, transparent food labelling, including clear health and environmental information
- GST removed from core plant-based foods to make healthy eating more affordable

An independent Commissioner for Animals

Animal welfare policy is currently overseen by the same government agency responsible for growing farming exports. That's a genuine conflict of interest. We want an independent Commissioner for Animals, similar to the Commissioner for Children, with real power to hold agencies to account and champion animal protection nationally.

We'll push for:

- An independent Commissioner with investigative and enforcement powers
- Proper funding for animal welfare research and policy
- Accountability for the agencies currently responsible for enforcement

Fixing our pound and shelter system

Thousands of healthy, adoptable dogs are euthanised in council pounds every year, often simply because of overcrowding, short reclaim windows, or fees families can't afford. We want rehoming to be the default nationwide, not the exception, and euthanasia used only ever as a genuine last resort.

We'll push for:

- Transparent public reporting from every council on outcomes for impounded animals
- Fairer, more flexible reclaim processes and fees
- Funded foster networks and widespread access to desexing

Smarter, more compassionate conservation

We care deeply about protecting native wildlife, and we know introduced species do cause real harm. But we don't believe mass killing is the answer, especially for cats, where there's often no reliable way to tell a community cat from a wild-living one. Habitat loss is the biggest driver of native species decline, and that's where solutions should start.

We'll push for:

- An end to lethal, poison-based control methods for cats
- Investment in desexing, Trap-Neuter-Return, and habitat restoration
- Conservation policy guided by evidence, not by fear or blame

Veterinary care people can actually afford

For many families, a sudden vet bill means an impossible choice. We want veterinary care treated as essential, not a luxury: GST removed from vet services, more publicly funded clinics in underserved regions, and funded desexing and wildlife care so access doesn't depend on income or postcode.

We'll push for:

- GST removed from all veterinary services
- A national network of publicly funded and mobile veterinary clinics
- Guaranteed funding for injured wildlife and desexing programmes

Getting money out of politics

Industries that profit from animal exploitation have far more access to political decision-makers than ordinary people do. We want donation caps, real-time lobbying transparency, and cooling-off periods so industry leaders can't move straight into government roles overseeing their own sector.

We'll push for:

- Lower donation limits and stronger disclosure rules
- Public, real-time reporting of lobbying meetings with government
- Cooling-off periods between industry leadership and ministerial roles

Making sure AI is used responsibly around animals

Artificial intelligence already manages hundreds of thousands of farmed animals in New Zealand, through automated monitoring, feeding and even virtual fencing, with no law written to account for it. We want animal welfare built into how these systems are designed and regulated, before harmful practices become locked in.

We'll push for:

- Animal welfare requirements written into AI governance and the Animal Welfare Act
- A ban on AI systems that increase confinement or remove meaningful human oversight
- Independent validation of any AI system marketed as improving welfare

Recognising companion animals as family

For many people, a companion animal is part of the family. We want statutory bereavement leave for the loss of a companion animal, and short paid leave when a new animal joins a household, so people aren't forced to use sick leave to grieve or settle a new pet in.

We'll push for:

- Up to five days' statutory bereavement leave for the loss of a companion animal
- Up to three days' leave when a new companion animal joins the family
- Emergency leave provisions that cover urgent animal care alongside human care

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This is a summary. Every commitment above is backed by detailed policy, evidence and legislative proposals in our full 2026 policy platform. If you'd like the short version of why we exist, start with our election manifesto.